

Alvar Aalto

Finnish architect, artist and designer Alvar Aalto (1898–1976) created buildings, furniture, textiles and glassware. His early career paralleled the rapid economic growth and industrialization of Finland during the first half of the 20th century, and his style developed from a form of classicism, through modernism in the 1930s, to a more organic, Nordic-inspired style from the 1940s. The Alvar Aalto Museum that he designed in his home city of Jyväskylä (1973) exemplifies his 'white period', as his later style is often known. His first public buildings – the Jyväskylä Workers' Club (1925), the Jyväskylä Defence Corps building (1926) and the Seinäjoki Defence Corps building (1924–9) – fuse neoclassicism with elements of modernism. His Viipuri Library (1927–35) in Vyborg, Russia, comprises two offset white rectangles, with an interior of natural materials, warm colours and undulating lines. His Säynätsalo Town Hall (opposite, 1951) is an innovative, organic, brick-built series of buildings, with 'butterfly trusses' supporting the main hall roof, arranged around a glazed central courtyard.

